PRELUDE XX

THE rich outpouring of lyric melody and chromatic two-part harmony, in Double Counterpoint invertible in melody as well as in position, obviously demands an expressive *legato* and *cantabile* in every note. The test phrase for the player's powers of natural and delicate expression is the joint from just before the fourth crotchet of bar 1 (G♯) to the first note of bar 2. When this and its variation in bars 8-9 and 9-10 can be played with convincing grace by either hand, there will be no further danger of the kind of bickering perkiness which still passes for Bach-scholarship among the superstitious. Another test by which the true Bach-player may be known is his instinctive recognition of the clavichord *Bebung-legato*, or the string-player's *louré*-stroke in the bass of bar 29, covering the whole bar or two half-bars in a *legato* which nearly ties the repeated notes, instead of the commonplace iambic slurring across the beats.

The fascinating and easy exercise of tracing all this wonderful counterpoint in its two pairs of whole-bar and half-bar themes, with their inversions and conversions, must not be allowed to produce a phrasing into nothing but single bars and half-bars. On the contrary, bars 1-3 must be taken together, and answered by the 4-bar period 4-7; and, again, bars 8-10 by 11-12, and thence to the double bar. Only with the quaver-figure of the second theme (bar 6) is it advisable clearly to make a fresh entry with the second quaver of the bar or half-bar, and then, of course, only where it is a full quaver and has not been shortened by overlapping into the last semiquaver of the companion figure. But the fresh entry is very useful after the middle of bar 10 and 12, as avoiding an effect of false relation. The same phrasing should be reproduced in bars 23-24, where it is only in the quaver figure that this half-bar theme is reproduced by inversion. In the first pair of themes it is not right to detach the first quaver from the others, though this occasionally happens later. But the inverted pair treats the first quaver as essential. And nobody would break up this ancient theme as it occurs in Bach's early Cantata *Nach Dir, Herr, verlanget mich*, where it is exactly the rising octave that is most expressive.

The flow should be very even. The ability to maintain a slow *tempo* without dragging depends entirely on the tone. The pianist should value all the colours attainable by mere variety of position—*e.g.*, the viola C-string quality of bars 11-14, and a flute-like transparency in all passages involving treble leger-lines, a *forte* there being detestable on the pianoforte, when the bass is remote enough to be thin but not deep enough to be impressive.

FUGUE XX

THE crotchets should be weightily detached, but by no means so short as the quavers marked by Bach himself (in his pupils' copies) by dashes which should be applied to all the quavers in the Fugue, except the mainly conjunct ones in bar 9 and the important Altnikol reading in bar 17. In bar 17 (as in the last beat of bar 25) they should be as heavy as the crotchets, if not actually

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legato. The slur indicating the phrasing of the First Countersubject is also authentic.* In bar 6 the autograph is preferable to the reading of the pupils' MSS., which carry on the quaver figure (E, C, B, G♯). In one of those MSS., in fact, that reading has been corrected back into that of the autograph. On the other hand, in bar 17 the pupils' reading (E as third quaver where the autograph has B) is finer. It has two points: First, it brings about the entry of the Subject in the same way as that at the end of bar 9 and of bar 25. Theoretically, no doubt, what happens in all three cases is a " tonal answer " with the first note shortened. This fact misleads the player into putting all his detached emphasis on to the last quaver. But the laws of tonal answers are not always, or often, laws of rhetoric; and the real point here is the way in which a few majestic steps (a longer descent each time) drift into the Subject. Rhetorically, then, these entries are best thought of as beginning on the beat and filling out the first interval of the Subject. The second point in these two readings (bars 6 and 17) is that by obliterating the allusion to the quaver-figure of the Subject they confine the use of that figure to the Second Countersubject and the Episodes. As the quaver-figure is itself obviously a diminution of the crotchets of the Subject, and as it takes a very neat and clear form in the Second Countersubject (see the bass of bar 7), whereby it completes a powerful Triple Counterpoint which is heard five times and in four out of the six possible permutations, it is well that its character should not be weakened by merely casual appearances that contribute nothing to its episodic development.

In the Episodes, the first of which is in bar 5 before the third voice has entered, a fresh demisemiquaver figure appears, and adds much to the torrential vigour already given by the First Countersubject and the giant strides of the Subject. The sonorous power of the piece is obvious from the outset; and in the place where the dialogue of the upper parts shows a more yielding mood (bars 19-20) the bass has already started on one of the most mountainous ascents ever packed into one sequence by any composer. Be sure to play the right hand here as in dialogue, and not as a single voice.

In the last bar the British Museum autograph ends with  ; but there is no doubt that the pupils' copies (which are unanimous here) represent Bach's own decision of what best suits the last chord of this stormy piece. The *tempo* is a dignified eight in the bar, neither to be hurried nor hindered. It is finely determined by the precise position of the accidentals in that mighty ascending bass (bar 19), which show Bach's characteristic refusal to anticipate his modulation by the slightest ornamental note. On the other hand, the flow should admit of the short episodic runs (bars 5, 6, 15, and 24) rolling slightly in Bach's *stile francese—i.e.*, a little sharply, through delay to the last moment. In bar 26 make no break where the middle part carries on the run.

* As implied by Bischoff, but he does not cite authorities. But no other phrasing is possible.